Noah E. Creany, PhD

noahecreany@gmail.com | 814.322.5996 | Website | ORCID | GitHub

Research

Protected Area Conservation & Management

My expertise lies in Protected Area Conservation and Recreation Management, specifically applied, interdisciplinary research that integrates social science and ecology to inform management through a social-ecological systems lens.

- Recreation Ecology
- Human Dimensions of Wildland Recreation
- Visitor Use Management & Monitoring

Professional Experience

Postdoctoral Research Fellow 2024-2025
Oak Ridge Institute for Science and Education (ORISE)/ U.S. Forest Service

- Optimized the U.S. Forest Service National Visitor Use Monitoring (NVUM) program using statistical modeling to reduce data collection intensity and costs while minimizing impacts on data utility.
- Developed gradient-boosted regression model using novel monitoring data to predict site-level daily forest visitation, and computer-vision object-detection workflow for automated trail-use monitoring.

Research Assistant 2017-2024
Utah State University

- Investigated recreation impacts on wildland ecosystems, employing advanced data analytics and machine learning techniques (Python, R) for regression, classification, and clustering.
- Managed and analyzed complex multi-modal datasets, including spatial, tabular, survey, and raster/imagery data.
- Collaborated with federal, state, and county land managers to ensure research deliverables met management priorities and timelines.

Education

Utah State University 2020-2024
PhD, Ecology *Logan, UT, USA*

- Research Assistant, Instructor of Record
- Dissertation: *Shifting Paradigms in Recreation and Parks and Protected Areas: Advancing Social-Ecological Systems Frameworks in Park and Protected Area Management*
- Major Professor: Dr. Christopher A. Monz, Supervising Committee: Dr. Mark Brunson, Dr. Wayne Freimund, Dr. Sarah Klain, Dr. Patrick Singleton.

Utah State University 2019
M.Sc., Recreation Resource Management *Logan, UT, USA*

- Thesis: *Kudos & KOMs: The Effect of Strava Use on Evaluations of Social and Managerial Conditions, Perceptions of Ecological Impacts, and Mountain Bike Spatial Behavior*
- Research Assistant/Teaching Assistant

Pennsylvania State University 2012
B.Sc., Community, Environment, and Development *University Park, PA, USA*

Funded Research

Rocky Mountain National Park Day Use Visitor Access Monitoring 2025
Rocky Mountain Conservancy $15,000

Rocky Mountain National Park Day Use Visitor Access Monitoring 2024
Rocky Mountain Conservancy $15,000

Awards

Utah State University Quinney College of Natural Resources 2023
Doctoral Student Researcher of the Year

Rocky Mountain Cooperative Ecosystem Studies Unit (CESU) 2023
Student Researcher (Honorable Mention)

Peer-Reviewed Articles

- **Creany, N.,** Monz, C., & Freimund, W. (2026). Strava Metro mobility data provides accurate estimates of recreation use in Urban-Proximate Protected Areas. *Journal of Outdoor Recreation and Tourism*. doi: 10.1016/j.jort.2025.101008
- Van Deursen, J., **Creany, N.,** Monz, C. A., & Freimund, W. (2025). Classifications of Recreation Specialization: Attitudinal and Behavioral Differences Across Specialization Types in the Nature Reserve of Orange County, CA, USA. *Journal of Park and Recreation Administration*. doi: 10.18666/JPRA-2025-12883
- Wheeler, I., Blair, P., **Creany, N.,** Manire, H., Morris, D., Mollett, S., Scearce, S. S., Stoellinger, T., Willoughby, J. R., & Dunning, K. H. (2025). Delisting the Northern Rocky Mountain gray wolf from the US Endangered Species Act: An assessment of political discourse over 20 years. *Wildlife Biology*. doi: 10.1002/wlb3.01589
- **Creany, N.,** Monz, C. A., & Esser, S. M. (2024). Understanding visitor attitudes towards the timed-entry reservation system in Rocky Mountain National Park: Contemporary managed access as a social-ecological system. *Journal of Outdoor Recreation and Tourism*. doi: 10.1016/j.jort.2024.100736
- Minehart, K., Antonio, A. D., **Creany, N.,** Monz, C., & Gutzwiller, K. (2024). Predicting trail condition using random forest models in urban-proximate nature reserves. *Environmental Challenges*. doi: 10.1016/j.envc.2024.100937

- Van Deursen, J., **Creany, N.,** Smith, B., Freimund, W., Avgar, T., & Monz, C. A. (2024). Recreation specialization: Resource selection functions as a predictive tool for protected area recreation management. *Applied Geography*. doi: 10.1016/j.apgeog.2024.103276
- Tomczyk, A. M., Ewertowski, M. W., **Creany, N.,** Ancin-Murguzur, F. J., & Monz, C. (2023). The application of unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV) surveys and GIS to the analysis and monitoring of recreational trail conditions. *International Journal of Applied Earth Observation and Geoinformation*. doi: 10.1016/j.jag.2023.103474
- **Creany, N.,** Monz, C. A., D'Antonio, A., Sisneros-Kidd, A., Wilkins, E. J., Nesbitt, J., & Mitrovich, M. (2021). Estimating trail use and visitor spatial distribution using mobile device data: An example from the nature reserve of orange county, California USA. *Environmental Challenges*. doi: 10.1016/j.envc.2021.100171
- Monz, C., **Creany, N.,** Nesbitt, J., & Mitrovich, M. (2021). Mobile Device Data Analysis to Determine the Demographics of Park Visitors. *Journal of Park and Recreation Administration*. doi: 10.18666/10.18666/JPRA-2020-10541
- Smith, J. W., Miller, A. B., Lamborn, C. C., Spernbauer, B. S., **Creany, N.,** Richards, J. C., Meyer, C., Nesbitt, J., Rempel, W., Wilkins, E. J., Miller, Z. D., Freimund, W., & Monz, C. (2021). Motivations and spatial behavior of OHV recreationists: A case-study from central Utah (USA). *Journal of Outdoor Recreation and Tourism*. doi: 10.1016/j.jort.2021.100426
- Wesstrom, S., **Creany, N.,** Monz, C. A., Miller, A., & D'Antonio, A. (2021). The Effect of a Vehicle Diversion Traffic Management Strategy on Spatio-Temporal Park Use: A Study in Rocky Mountain National Park, Colorado, Usa. *Journal of Park and Recreation Administration*. doi: 10.18666/jpra-2021-10746

Manuscripts in Preparation

- **Creany, N.,**Monz, C. - Direct Trail Management on High-Use Trails Improves the Quality of Recreation Experiences. Target Journal: *Landscape and Urban Planning*.

Natural Resource & Technical Reports

- Graham, R., Creany, N., & Monz, C. (2021). *Spatial Behavior of Backcountry Anglers and Hikers in Rocky Mountain National Park* [Natural Resource Technical Report]. National Park Service.
- Sisneros-Kidd, A., D'Antonio, A. L., Creany, N., Monz, C. A., & Shoenleber, C. (2019). *Recreation Use and Human Valuation on the Nature Reserve of Orange County, California*. Orange County, California: Utah State University.

Professional Affiliations

- Ecological Society of America (ESA) — 2022-Present
- Recreation Ecology Research Network — 2019-Present

Professional Service

Associate Editor — 2026 - Present
Journal of Outdoor Recreation and Tourism

- Manage and referee the peer review process, ensuring high standards for research quality, robustness, and relevance.

Journal Peer Reviewer 2024-Present
Scientific Reports
- Peer-reviewed manuscripts related to recreation management.

Journal Peer Reviewer 2021 - Present
Journal of Park and Recreation Administration
- Peer-reviewed manuscripts concerning the application of mobile device data for recreation use estimation.

Journal Peer Reviewer 2022 - Present
Landscape and Urban Planning
- Peer-reviewed manuscripts related to park and protected area planning and management.

Teaching Experience

Data Analysis and Programming for Natural Resource Management Spring 2024
Instructor of Record: NR6580 *Utah State University*

Wildland Recreation Behavior Fall 2024
Instructor of Record: ENVS 4500 *Utah State University*

Wildland Recreation Behavior Fall 2022
Instructor of Record: ENVS 4500 *Utah State University*

Wildland Recreation Behavior Fall 2021
Instructor of Record: ENVS 4500 *Utah State University*

Wildland Recreation Behavior Fall 2020
Instructor of Record: ENVS 4500 *Utah State University*

Technical Skills

Programming Languages
Python, R, ArcPy, SAS

Software
Google Cloud Compute, Google Earth Engine, ArcGIS, QGIS, Adobe CC, LaTex, Quarto